Funny 'Barry Loser' Books Are Being Turned Into a Cartoon

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Barry Loser is a 10-year-old with a wild imagination, and he may soon be on TV. The award-winning "Barry Loser" children's book series by Jim Smith is being turned into an **animated** show.

The books have won the Roald Dahl Funny Prize, been **translated** into 17 languages and sold more than a million copies around the world. The series includes 11 books and **graphic novels**. They follow Barry, a lovable kid who lives in an ordinary British town called Mogden. Barry can turn something as simple as a trip to the store or a visit to grandma's into a huge, over-the-top adventure.

The cartoon is being made by Big Little Fish Television from the U.K. and Frog Head from Italy. It is planned as 52 **episodes**, each 11 minutes long. A British streaming service for kids, ITVX Kids, has already picked up the show. The team says the cartoon will keep the loose, hand-drawn look of the books.

For Big Little Fish's leader, Mark Procter, the show is personal. "About three years ago, 'Barry Loser' was my boy's favorite title," he told Variety. "We were devouring these books every night."

Making a cartoon costs a lot of money. The **producers** say about 60 to 70 percent of the money is already in place. This week, they are presenting the show at the MIA Market in Rome, Italy, which runs October 19 to 23. They hope to find more partners there. They plan to finish raising money in early 2027 and then start making the show.

Procter joked that getting the series made would let him "be the best dad in the world."

Word Treasure

animated -- Animated means made with moving drawings or computer images, like a cartoon.

episodes -- Episodes are the separate parts of a TV series that are shown one at a time.

graphic novels -- Graphic novels are books that tell a story mostly through comic-style pictures.

translated -- Translated means changed from one language into another.

producers -- Producers are the people who organize and pay for making a show or movie.

Background you need

Many popular children's books are adapted into TV shows or movies, which means the story is retold in a new form.

An animated series is made from many drawings or computer images shown quickly one after another so they seem to move.

Making a cartoon is expensive, so producers often team up with companies in other countries and look for broadcasters to help pay for it.

Industry markets are events where producers present their shows to TV networks and other possible partners.

Break it down

LEAD: The 'Barry Loser' children's books are becoming an animated show
BOOKS: award-winning series by Jim Smith, 11 books and graphic novels, over a million copies, 17 languages
STORY: 10-year-old Barry turns ordinary moments in Mogden into big adventures
SHOW: 52 episodes of 11 minutes, hand-drawn look
+- WHO: Big Little Fish Television (U.K.) and Frog Head (Italy); picked up by ITVX Kids
+- WHY: a passion project for Mark Procter, whose son loved the books
NEXT STEP: pitching at Rome's MIA Market, October 19 to 23; 60-70% of money in place
OPEN QUESTION: Will they raise the rest in time to start in 2027?

Why it matters

Popular books for young readers often reach even more kids when they become TV shows. The story also shows that making a cartoon takes years of planning and many partners.

Test what you remember

1. Who created the 'Barry Loser' books?

(A) Barry Loser
(B) Jim Smith
(C) Roald Dahl
(D) Mark Procter

2. How many languages have the books been translated into?

(A) 2
(B) 52
(C) 11
(D) 17

3. What can Barry turn a trip to the store into?

(A) A boring chore
(B) A huge, over-the-top adventure
(C) A science project
(D) A sports game

4. How many episodes is the cartoon planned to have?

(A) 100
(B) 25
(C) 11
(D) 52

5. Why is the show personal for Mark Procter?

(A) 'Barry Loser' was his son's favorite and they read the books every night
(B) He draws the cartoons himself
(C) He wrote the books
(D) He grew up in Mogden

6. Why are the producers going to the MIA Market in Rome?

(A) To film the show
(B) To win a prize
(C) To find more partners and money
(D) To sell toys

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: D 3: B 4: D 5: A 6: C

Questions to think about

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):